

Cold Email Diagnostic

A 10-point self-review, three annotated teardowns, and a revision worksheet for beginner sellers.

Coaching rule: Treat word count, subject length, pronouns, and reading level as diagnostic checks - not universal laws. Buyer, role, context, and message quality still matter.

10-point scorecard

#	Check	Pass standard	Score
1	Readable length	The email is easy to scan. For executive cold outreach, 50-100 words is a useful test range.	0 / 1
2	Subject line	Short, specific, and anchored to the buyer's world; 1-4 words is a useful test for executives.	0 / 1
3	Relevant opening	Begins with a verified signal, priority, or reason for this person now.	0 / 1
4	One problem	Names one plausible operational issue without claiming the assumption as fact.	0 / 1
5	Buyer outcome	Explains the useful change for the buyer, not a list of product features.	0 / 1
6	Credibility	Uses one concise, verifiable proof point or mechanism.	0 / 1
7	Low-friction CTA	Asks for interest or offers something useful before demanding calendar time.	0 / 1
8	Plain language	Avoids jargon, inflated claims, and sentences the reader must decode.	0 / 1
9	Mobile scan	Uses short paragraphs and minimal links or attachments.	0 / 1
10	GIFT check	Grounded, individual, fact-checked, and tone-matched.	0 / 1

8-10: Ready for final verification 5-7: Revise 0-4: Rebuild around one buyer reason

Teardown 1: seller-centered and overpacked

BEFORE Subject: Comprehensive AI-Powered Pipeline Acceleration Solutions Hi John, my name is Dave and I am an account executive at FastSales. We provide an award-winning platform with automation, analytics, integrations, and AI that helps Fortune 500 companies increase pipeline. Can I get 30 minutes Thursday for a demo?	WHY IT STRUGGLES Long subject. Opens with the seller. Stacks features. Uses broad proof. Asks for significant time before establishing relevance.
AFTER Subject: acme ramp time Hi John - saw Acme is hiring six enterprise SDRs this quarter. Teams expanding that quickly often revisit how new reps learn account research without sending generic outreach. We built a one-page ramp checklist for that transition. Worth sending it over?	COACHING MOVE Verify every account fact, preserve the hypothesis language, and make one easy-to-answer offer.

Teardown 2: fake personalization

BEFORE Subject: loved your post Hi Maya - loved your recent post! Your background is impressive. We help sales leaders improve performance with innovative AI. Do you have 30 minutes next week?	WHY IT STRUGGLES Praise is not a business reason. The post is not connected to a priority. The offer is vague and the meeting request is premature.
AFTER Subject: manager coaching load Hi Maya - your post on doubling the SDR team mentioned weekly call reviews as the current coaching rhythm. When headcount grows faster than review capacity, managers often lose practice time with new reps. I have a five-minute peer-review format that may help. Useful?	COACHING MOVE Verify every account fact, preserve the hypothesis language, and make one easy-to-answer offer.

Teardown 3: invented pain and heavy CTA

BEFORE Subject: your pipeline problem Hi Luis - your team is clearly struggling to create pipeline. Our solution can fix that and deliver 40% growth. Click this link, read the case study, watch the demo, and book time on my calendar.	WHY IT STRUGGLES Presents an assumption as fact. Makes an unsupported outcome claim. Includes multiple competing actions and creates trust risk.
AFTER Subject: regional pipeline mix Hi Luis - your earnings note called out new mid-market coverage in two regions. That shift can make early pipeline quality harder to compare across territories. We use a simple coverage worksheet that separates volume from qualified value. Open to a copy?	COACHING MOVE Verify every account fact, preserve the hypothesis language, and make one easy-to-answer offer.

Revision worksheet

Rewrite one real or practice email. Keep observed facts separate from your hypothesis.

Element	Your revision
Verified signal	
Source and date	
Plausible implication	
Buyer outcome	
Proof or mechanism	
Low-friction offer	
Final subject	
Final email	

External validation: Gong reports 1-4 word subjects and 50-100 word emails performed strongly in its executive-email analysis; Gong also found interest CTAs performed best in cold email. Lavender supports testing mobile formatting by buyer context. These are research-backed starting points, not promises.

Sources: <https://www.gong.io/blog/do-execs-really-reply-to-cold-email-here-s-what-the-data-says> | <https://www.gong.io/blog/this-surprising-cold-email-cta-will-help-you-book-a-lot-more-meetings> | <https://lavender.ai/blog/5-takeaways-from-our-latest-cold-email-benchmark-report>

Next step: Continue with the Cold Email Pro Pack or practice buyer replies in the VSM AI Role-Play Lab.